

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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R

Rebuilding of Jerusalem

The wall of Jerusalem held great political, social, and religious importance for the people of Judah (see Nehemiah 2:10, 19; 4:1–15; 6:1–14). In ancient and even modern times, a city without walls cannot last long. Walls protected cities from invading armies and common criminals.

By Nehemiah's time, Jerusalem's walls had been in ruins for over a hundred years, since the city's destruction in 586 BC. The ruined wall was a shameful reminder that God had punished the city, fulfilling the covenant curses due to the people's sins (Nehemiah 1:2–7; 2:17). Rebuilding the wall would show God's blessing and prove that he was restoring the covenant people. Israel's enemies knew that if they rebuilt the wall, the Jews would gain political power, security, and self-rule. Therefore, they strongly opposed the rebuilding.

Under Nehemiah's leadership, the people of Judea rebuilt the entire wall in just fifty-two days during the fall of 445 BC. This quick and successful reconstruction can encourage Christians that with God's help, they can achieve remarkable things (see Nehemiah 2:18; 4:14–15, 20; 6:16).

Passages for Further Study

Nehemiah 1:2–4; 2:10–20; 3:1–32; 4:1–23; 6:1–16; Psalm 51:16–18; Isaiah 22:5; 26:1–3; Revelation 21:10–27

Religious Hypocrisy

Religious hypocrisy happens when people selectively obey rules and only pretend to follow God's law without real change in their motives and lives. Those who boast about their religious commitment often lack a true desire to obey God.

The prophet Isaiah preached to people who seemed to be very religious. They fasted, prayed, celebrated holy days, and brought sacrifices to Jerusalem. Yet God rejected these practices.

Why? These acts had value because the Lord himself had prescribed them! But the people's worship was not sincere. It lacked the personal holiness and social justice that God requires (see, for example, Leviticus 19:13–17). The people of Judah had become religious hypocrites.

Many years after Isaiah, Jesus addressed the hypocrisy of the Pharisees. He urged them to obey all

of what God had revealed, not just the parts that made them popular (Matthew 23:1–36, especially Matthew 23:23). The apostles Paul and James also emphasized the difference between performing religious acts and having true spirituality (1 Corinthians 3:1–23; James 1:21–2:13).

Jesus' criticism of the Pharisees also warns us. We should not imitate them (see Matthew 6:1–18; 1 Peter 2:1). Instead, Jesus tells us to be genuine with God and others and obey all his commands. In our worship of God, we must go farther than religion forms with a focus on outward actions.

Passages for Further Study

Psalm 50:16–23; Proverbs 15:8; 26:23; Isaiah 1:11–15; 29:13–15; 58:2–7; Jeremiah 7:4–10; 12:2; Ezekiel 33:30–31; Hosea 8:13; Amos 5:21–24; Micah 3:11; Zechariah 7:5–6; Malachi 2:13–14; Matthew 6:1–18; 23:1–36; Titus 1:15–16; James 1:21–27; 1 Peter 2:1; 1 John 2:4, 9; 4:20

Remaining in Christ

The Greek term *menō*, often translated as “remain,” “stay,” or “abide,” appears often in Jesus' teachings about deep, intimate, and lasting relationships. For example, Jesus said, “If you continue in [*menō en*, ‘stay in’] My word, you are truly My disciples” (John 8:31). This means the life of a follower of Jesus (a disciple) is fully shaped by Jesus' message.

Jesus also explained how the Son is in the Father and the Father is in the Son (John 14:10–11). In a similar way, when we remain in Jesus, the Son is in us, and we are in the Father and the Son (17:21–23). Both the Father and the Son come and make their “home” within disciples.

This mutual “living inside” shows what it means for a disciple to remain in Jesus. We cannot make our relationship permanent by ourselves. Only God's gracious action through his Holy Spirit makes the relationship lasting. Both God and the disciple must commit. The connection between God and the disciple is not temporary. It is a lasting and eternal relationship (see 1 John 2:14, 17).

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 33:11; 34:28; Joshua 7:11–12; 1 Samuel 16:22; Psalms 22:11, 19; 101:7; Daniel 1:21; 2:49; Haggai 2:5; Luke 15:31; 22:28; John 6:56; 8:31; 15:1–17; Philipians 4:1; 1 John 2:19, 27–28; 3:24; 2 John 1:9; Revelation 2:10; 13:10

Remember Him

God saved the Israelites from slavery in Egypt and made them his people. Yet, God knew they would forget him (Deuteronomy 31:16–21). Moses warned the people entering the promised land to always remember what the Lord had done for them (Deuteronomy 8:1–20). The Israelites eventually forgot the Lord, which led to their exile from the land God had given them (see 2 Kings 17:5–23; see also Jeremiah 2:32).

The Teacher in the book of Ecclesiastes emphasizes the importance of remembering the Lord. Throughout the book, the Teacher reflects on how many aspects of life are temporary and useless or meaningless. He concludes by urging readers to remember the one who is eternal (Ecclesiastes 12:1–7). No one stays young forever, aging and death are universal.

Therefore, the Teacher encourages people to focus on God while they are young, before it is too late. All people are accountable to God for their actions (Ecclesiastes 12:13–14). Our present lives should be guided by the reality of his future judgment.

Passages for Further Study

Deuteronomy 8:1–20; Ecclesiastes 12:1–7, 13–14; 1 Corinthians 3:12–14

The Remnant

The remnant is a small group of people who remain faithful to God. When foreign armies threatened to invade, and people feared being taken away from their homeland, the idea of the remnant was a source of hope for God's people (see Micah 2:12–13; 4:6–8). The exile of the Israelites to Babylon was God's judgment on his people. But God showed he would not destroy them completely (see Hosea 11:8–11). Preserving a remnant showed God's mercy and faithfulness.

The idea of a remnant was central to the prophet Isaiah's message. One of his sons was named Shear-jashub, which means "a remnant will return" (Isaiah 7:3; see 10:21). Isaiah prophesied that when God judged his people with destruction, he would save the remnant to be the starting point of a new beginning. This destruction happened when the Babylonians attacked from 605 to 586 BC.

Because the population of Judah would be greatly reduced (as the northern kingdom of Israel had been already), this remnant would be a very small beginning. Isaiah describes the remnant as:

- a "Branch" (4:2),
- a "stump" (6:13),
- a community of the "poor" and "needy" (25:4), and

- grain that "will be gathered one by one" (27:12–13).

This remnant was to trust in God while waiting for him to establish his rule and reward them (see 3:10; 40:10). God promised that this small group would grow into a large crowd from both Israel and other nations (27:6; 60:3).

In fulfillment of prophecy, a remnant of God's people were allowed to return to Jerusalem and rebuild the temple during King Cyrus of Persia's rule (Ezra 1:2–4). Ezra the priest saw this preservation of a remnant as an act of God's grace. He also knew this grace could be put at risk if the people followed their ancestors in disobedience (Ezra 9:5–15).

The idea of the remnant encourages people to remain faithful to God, even when others are not. For Israel and Judah, this faithfulness would restore their land and bring the blessings God promised his people.

Passages for Further Study

2 Kings 19:31; 2 Chronicles 36:20; Ezra 9:14; Isaiah 1:8–9; 4:1–3; 6:13; 10:19–22; 11:10–16; 27:12–13; 28:5; 37:31–32; 46:3–4; Jeremiah 6:9; 23:3–4; 31:7–8; Amos 5:15; Micah 2:12; 4:6–7; 5:7–8; 7:18; Zephaniah 3:11–13

Remove the Evil

Sin is so opposed to God's holiness that it cannot exist with him. The same should be true for God's people. God is holy, and he expects his people to show his holiness (Leviticus 11:45; 19:2).

God required severe responses to remove sin from the covenant community. God offered forgiveness, but only to those who were truly repentant. Those who became stubborn could expect God's judgment. This judgment was a cleansing process that consumed sinners and their sins, leaving nothing behind (see Deuteronomy 9:3; 13:5; Isaiah 33:14; Hebrews 12:28–29). This cleansing is meant to heal the community of believers in the Lord and discourage others from rebelling against him (Deuteronomy 17:13).

In the Old Testament, God often judged his people immediately (see, for example, Numbers 11:1–3; 16:1–50; Joshua 7). This made his people very aware of his demand for obedience and the consequences of disobedience.

God's final punishment is set for the future day of justice when he will reveal and judge the sins of all people (Romans 14:10; 2 Corinthians 5:10; Hebrews 9:27; 1 Peter 4:5). Yet, some disasters can be seen as God's judgment on his disobedient people (for example, Acts 5:1–11; see 1 Corinthians 11:27–30). It is still

“a fearful thing to fall into the hands of the living God” (Hebrews 10:31).

Passages for Further Study

Leviticus 19:1-2; Deuteronomy 9:3-6; 13:5; 17:2-13; Joshua 7:1-26; 2 Chronicles 34:3-8; Isaiah 1:24-26; 4:2-6; 33:14; Ezekiel 20:32-38; Matthew 18:8-9; Acts 5:1-11; Romans 14:10; 1 Corinthians 11:27-30; 2 Corinthians 5:10; Hebrews 9:27-28; 10:31; 12:28-29; James 5:19-20; 1 Peter 4:5

Resurrection in the Old Testament

Many Old Testament passages suggest that the place where dead people are is a location from which people do not return (see, for example, Job 7:6-21; Psalm 6:5; Isaiah 38:18-19). Yet, some passages suggest the idea of that people can live again after death (see, for example, Job 19:25-27; Psalm 16:10-11; Isaiah 26:19). Daniel 12:1-3 teaches that God will bring the dead back to life. God told the prophet Daniel that he would be part of this resurrection (12:13). Belief in the resurrection of the dead became more common during the period between the Old and New Testament writings. This was shown by the popularity of the idea during the time of Jesus.

According to this passage from Daniel, the resurrection will be different for people.

Two groups will resurrect:

1. Those who will experience new life.
2. Those who will experience shame.

These groups have different beliefs about right and wrong, different standards for behavior, and different ways of following God. The resurrection will reveal a person's true nature. Everyone will be accountable to God Most High in a moral and spiritual way.

The first group will have a new life called “everlasting life.” In the Old Testament, this phrase appears only in Daniel 12:2. Here it seems to refer more to the quality of life than its length. God will cleanse and purify those who experience this life. The similes “shine like the brightness of the heavens” and “shine like the stars forever and ever” describe their moral glory.

The second group will encounter everlasting shame and disgrace because they are not morally or spiritually renewed. The New Testament book of Revelation expands on these two groups from Daniel's vision (see Revelation 20:4-6, 11-15).

God's people will finally escape death. Those resurrected to life have their names written in the Book of Life (see Daniel 7:9-10; 10:21; Revelation 20:12). The

Judge, known as the Ancient One, declares them righteous.

Passages for Further Study

Job 19:25-27; Daniel 12:1-3, 13; Matthew 27:50-53; 28:1-20; 1 Corinthians 15:1-58; Revelation 20:1-15

The Resurrection of Jesus

The Bible clearly describes how Jesus physically rose from the dead through God's power. However, many other explanations have been suggested:

1. Jesus did not actually die. He fainted and later woke up in a cold tomb. Some call this the “the swoon theory.”
2. Jesus' disciples stole his body and lied about the resurrection (see Matthew 28:12-15).
3. The disciples saw things that were not there (called hallucinations) and had dreams, causing them to confuse these experiences with a physical resurrection.
4. The resurrection is a personal faith experience, not a historical event.

These ideas often come from doubt about supernatural or miraculous events. They overlook that for New Testament writers and their audiences, the term resurrection meant an actual dead body coming back to life (see 1 Corinthians 15).

There is historical evidence for Jesus' resurrection. The biblical accounts are reliable as well. These proofs include:

1. The empty tomb.
2. Women as witnesses, which was unusual at that time. This is because people then considered women's testimony less reliable than men's.
3. The consistent accounts of Jesus' appearances after his resurrection.
4. How the disciples transformed from fearful to fearless followers.
5. The disciples' ability to accept the shame of following the religion of a crucified man. According to Deuteronomy 21:23, such a death meant being under God's curse.

Judaism had no concept of a Messiah (God's chosen one) who would die and then rise again that could easily be applied to Jesus. Creating a story that no one would find believable would not have made sense. The most reasonable conclusion is exactly what the New Testament declares: Jesus did rise from the dead.

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 16:21; 17:9, 23; 20:19; 26:32; 28:1–10; Mark 14:28; Luke 9:22; 14:14; John 2:19–22; 5:21; 6:39–40; 11:1–44; 14:20; 21:14; Acts 1:21–22; 2:22–36; 3:15, 26; 4:2, 10, 33; 5:30; 10:39–40; 13:29–31; 17:18, 32; 23:6–10; Romans 1:4; 4:24–25; 6:4–5, 9; 7:4; 8:11, 34; 10:9; 1 Corinthians 6:14; 15:4, 12–23, 35, 42–44, 52; 2 Corinthians 1:9; 4:14; 5:15; Galatians 1:1; Ephesians 1:19–20; 2:5–6; Philippians 3:10–11; Colossians 2:12; 3:1; 1 Thessalonians 1:10; 4:14; 2 Timothy 2:8, 18; Hebrews 6:2; 11:35; 1 Peter 1:21; 3:18, 21; Revelation 20:4–8, 11–15

The Resurrection of the Dead

Jesus spoke about a future resurrection for everyone. God will raise up all people to eternal life or to judgment (Mark 12:26–27; John 5:28–29; 6:39–40, 44, 54; 11:25–26; see also Luke 20:34–36). When Jesus returns, all his followers will resurrect to be with him forever (1 Thessalonians 4:13–18; see also 2 Corinthians 5:1–10).

This strong hope defined the perspective of early Christians. They endured suffering by focusing on the life to come (2 Corinthians 4:16–18; compare Hebrews 12:2). They expected Jesus to return, resurrect their bodies, and anticipated living with him forever (1 Peter 1:3–6, 23). They based their faith on the foundation of Jesus' own bodily resurrection (1 Corinthians 15:12–20; Acts 4:33; see also 2 Corinthians 4:14).

Resurrection bodies will be very different from the bodies we have now, which have limits and weaknesses. These new bodies will be like Christ's own resurrection body: glorious, strong, never dying, and spiritual (1 Corinthians 15:35–58).

Christians are already united to Christ, so they begin experiencing resurrection life now. They “were raised” with Christ and are “alive to God in Christ Jesus” (Romans 6:4–11; 8:10–11; Colossians 2:12). Their lives now focus on spiritual realities of heaven, not worldly things (Colossians 3:1–4). Christians can experience the transforming power of this new life, which frees them from sin and death (Romans 8:1–4). In all challenges, they trust in God's resurrection power, not themselves (2 Corinthians 1:9).

Passages for Further Study

Job 19:25–27; Psalms 16:10; 49:15; Daniel 12:2–3; Matthew 16:21; 28:1–10; Mark 12:18–27; John 3:13–16; 5:25–30; 6:39–40; 11:21–27; Acts 2:23–24; 3:14–15; 4:33; 10:39–41; 17:2–3; 24:15; 26:22–23; Romans 1:4; 4:25; 6:4–11; 8:10–11; 1 Corinthians 15:12–58; 2 Corinthians 1:8–9; 4:13–18; 5:1–10; Ephesians 1:19–20; Colossians 2:12; 3:1–4; 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18; 1 Peter 1:3–6, 23; Revelation 20:11–15; 21:1–7; 22:1–6

Retribution

God gave humans the task of having children and taking care of the world (Genesis 1:28). Yet, as the population increased, so did spiritual evil, violence, and murder (4:8, 23; 6:5, 11–13). This led to a corrupt world that required cleansing.

The purpose of the great flood during the time of Noah was to cleanse the world and retribution against those who did wrong. Retribution means “giving what is due” and usually refers to a penalty for bad actions. Retribution comes from the belief that the world has a moral order, which must be maintained or restored (see Psalm 7:14–16; Proverbs 11:17–21; 26:27).

God keeps moral order by giving justice, punishing evil actions, and rewarding good behavior (Galatians 6:7–8). Since God oversees the world, it never becomes totally overcome by moral disorder. People are accountable to God for their actions.

Some examples of God's justice are:

- The judgment and exile of Adam and Eve from the garden of Eden (Genesis 3:8–24);
- Cain's punishment for killing his brother Abel (4:10–15); and
- The worldwide flood (chapters 6–7).

These events show a God who rules over everything and gives fair punishment as part of his good plans for the world (see also Numbers 16; Deuteronomy 30:15–20; Joshua 7; Micah 2:1–3).

Retribution is one way God shows his righteousness. It cleanses the world for his kingdom of peace. Through retribution, God announces his rule over all and exercises justice against those who reject his rule or defy his commands (Deuteronomy 7:10; Psalm 149; Proverbs 15:25; Micah 5:15; 1 Corinthians 16:22; Galatians 1:8–9; 2 Thessalonians 1:5–10).

For God's people, retribution acts as his discipline. It intends to restore their covenant relationship with him (see Isaiah 44:22; Jeremiah 3:12–14; Lamentations 3:19–33; Hosea 14:1–2; Joel 2:12–13; see also Hebrews 12:5–11). When God's people experience his discipline, they can respond with hope because God's truth and righteousness will win (Psalm 58:10–11). God will redeem and restore those who trust in him (Leviticus 26:40–45; Hosea 2:2–23).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 6:1–7:24; Leviticus 26:14–39; Psalms 7:6–17; 57:6; 95:8–11; Proverbs 6:27–35; 26:27; Micah 2:1–3; Romans 2:5–16; Galatians 6:7–8; Hebrews 10:26–31; 12:5–11, 25–29

The Return of God's Presence with His People

The descriptions of the Israelite exile include the terrible reality that, as part of his judgment, God removed his presence from his people and from the holy city of Jerusalem. This idea is most obviously present in a vision by the prophet Ezekiel. He saw God's glorious presence leaving the temple (Ezekiel 10:1-22; 11:22-23). The prophets talked about the future return of God's people to the land. They often mentioned the return of God's presence (see, for example, Isaiah 52:7-8; Ezekiel 43:1-9).

The prophet Zechariah focused on the Lord returning to his people. He believed God would live among them again, and the Lord's glory would be in Jerusalem (Zechariah 1:16; 2:5, 10-11; 8:3, 23). God's presence would return when they rebuilt the temple. This would bring spiritual rebirth or newness and plenty of crops (1:17; 4:8-9; 6:15; see also Haggai 2:19).

In the future, God's presence would save Jerusalem and Israel from enemies. The Lord would be king over the earth. Everyone would worship the one true God (Zechariah 9:16; 10:6; 12:9; 14:9). Both now and in the future, the Lord's return to Jerusalem linked to the work of God's Spirit (4:6; 12:10; see also Haggai 2:5).

Zechariah's promise of the Lord's presence in Jerusalem prophesied the arrival of Jesus the Messiah (God's chosen one). It emphasized the amazing mystery of God's Word becoming man and living among humanity (John 1:14).

Sections for Additional Review

Genesis 26:3; 31:3; Exodus 3:12; Deuteronomy 31:23; Joshua 1:5; Judges 6:16; Isaiah 7:14; 43:2; 52:8; Ezekiel 37:27; Joel 3:21; Haggai 2:5; Zechariah 1:16-17; 2:5, 10-11; 4:6; 8:3, 23; 14:9; John 1:14

Returning to the Lord

The Old Testament prophets often told the people of Israel to return to the Lord, both before and after the exile to Babylon (see, for example, Isaiah 55:6-7; Hosea 6:1-3; Haggai 1:12; Malachi 3:7). This meant a renewed commitment to obey God. They had abandoned the true God and started worshiping other gods, which led to his judgment. This judgment resulted in the destruction of the temple and their exile. The future restoration and blessing of God's people depended on their obedience to him.

The prophet Zechariah's main message to those returning to Jerusalem from exile is plain in his opening statement: "Return to Me, declares the LORD

of Hosts, and I will return to you, says the LORD of Hosts" (Zechariah 1:3). Zechariah urged the people of Israel to renew their commitment to their special agreement with God (the covenant). He warned them to learn from their ancestors who were unfaithful to the covenant. This had severe consequences (7:11-14).

Zechariah cared about Israel's covenant with God and social justice. Returning to the Lord leads to obedience and practicing justice, honesty, fairness, mercy, and kindness (Zechariah 7:9-10; 8:16-17). Zechariah's focus on right relationships with God and others anticipated Jesus' teaching. He said the greatest commandments are to love God above everything and to love your neighbor as yourself (Matthew 22:34-40).

Passages for Further Study

1 Samuel 7:2-11; Isaiah 1:16-20; 55:7; Hosea 6:1-3; 14:1-7; Haggai 1:12; Zechariah 1:3; 7:9-14; 8:16-17; Malachi 3:7; Matthew 3:2-10; 22:34-40; Acts 17:24-31

Rich and Poor in the Gospel of Luke

In Luke's Gospel, entering or becoming excluded from the kingdom of God involves a reversal of worldly wealth. Mary, the mother of Jesus, proclaimed that God would elevate the poor and humble while humbling the rich and powerful (Luke 1:52-53). Jesus declared in Nazareth that the gospel is "good news to the poor" (4:18). He blessed the poor and hungry and warned the rich and satisfied (6:20-26). This challenged the common belief that God blessed rich people and cursed poor people.

Several of Jesus' parables strongly warn about the danger of wealth. The parable of the rich fool shows what happens when someone stores up treasures on earth instead of building a strong relationship with God (Luke 12:13-21). The parable of the rich man and Lazarus illustrates the eternal consequences of ignoring the poor and helpless while enjoying life's comforts (16:19-31). The rich man who asked Jesus how to gain eternal life felt devastated when Jesus told him to sell all he had and give to the poor (18:18-23).

Who are the poor in Luke's Gospel? Are they physically poor people or those poor in spirit (compare Matthew 5:3)? It is probably both. The physically poor, who have very little, naturally depend on God for their needs. Rich and powerful people often rely on themselves, forgetting their need for God. Rich people cannot enter God's kingdom if they trust in their wealth to get them there (16:25-26). God accepts those who trust only in him.

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 5:3; Luke 1:52–53; 4:18; 6:20–25; 12:13–34; 14:12–23; 16:19–31; 18:18–30

The Righteous Suffer

The book of Job invites readers to examine why we have faith in God. Job lost his possessions, family, and friends. This deeply tested his faith. Yet, he kept trusting God and proved that when Satan accused him, Satan was wrong.

Sin causes suffering, but the book of Job shows that suffering is not always because of a person's sin. Human suffering is more complex than just behavior and consequence. Some people today wrongly believe that being godly leads to material wealth, like Job's friends did. This view has problems, as history shows. There are many examples of righteous people who suffer, including Jesus Christ.

Scripture tells us that Christians must also share in Christ's suffering. It says "our present sufferings are not comparable to the glory that will be revealed in us" (Romans 8:17–18). Being a disciple of Christ means being willing to follow him into suffering (see Luke 9:23–25; Philippians 3:10–11).

Even in his complaints, Job recognized that only God could provide the answers he needed. When Job wished for death, he sought relief until God could deal him under better conditions (Job 14:13). When Job wanted "a mediator," it was to help him find favor with God (9:33–35). When Job complained that God did not listen, it was because he knew his answers had to come from God (see 19:25–27). This is essential to faith.

We cannot know or understand everything (see Genesis 2:16–17; Deuteronomy 29:29; Acts 1:7; 1 Thessalonians 5:1–2). Some things are for God alone to understand and guide according to his will. We should live by faith. Even when we suffer, we can trust God (see Romans 8:26–39).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 4:4–8; 26:17–33; 31:38–42; 37:2–36; 39:1–20; Exodus 1:8–11; 1 Samuel 18:10–11, 28–29; 19:10; 22:1–19; 1 Kings 21:1–15; 2 Chronicles 24:20–22; Job 9:33–35; 14:13; 19:25–27; Isaiah 54:17; Jeremiah 11:18–21; 26:1–23; 38:1–13; Matthew 23:29–37; John 5:24; 15:20; Acts 6:8–7:60; Romans 8:17–18, 26–39; Hebrews 12:1–13; 1 Peter 4:12–16

Righteousness by Faith

A key question in the early church was whether gentiles (non-Jewish people) who accepted the good news about Jesus needed to follow Jewish rules (including circumcision) to become part of God's family.

For the apostle Paul, the answer was simple. People cannot make themselves right with God by their own efforts. Only Jesus could accomplish (and has accomplished) what was necessary for reconciliation with God. Salvation is a gift of God's grace received through faith. Our response is to trust in Christ, give thanks for what he has done, and live in a way that reflects his love and truth.

For Jewish Christians in the first century, it was hard to accept this answer. From the time of Abraham, right relationship with God had been marked by circumcision, the ceremony of cutting off the male foreskin (Genesis 17:9–14). Every male who was part of God's family had to be circumcised, and those who neglected to do so were cut off from God's people. Those who had received circumcision were also expected to keep the rest of the law, including the Sabbath and dietary rules about food.

When Christianity spread from Jews to non-Jews, it was natural for questions to arise. Do Christians need to be circumcised (and keep God's law in general) to be accepted as part of God's family? Or does God accept people because of their faith in Christ's work on the cross? As Paul's mission to gentiles advanced, these questions became urgent.

The apostle Peter understood from his vision in Joppa and his experience in Caesarea that God has accepted gentiles as gentiles, because of their faith in Christ's finished work (Acts 10:9–11:18). They did not have to become Jewish by practicing circumcision or the ceremonial laws. Christ provided them open access to God by faith. Peter and the Jerusalem church therefore welcomed gentile believers into fellowship. But later, Peter temporarily stopped eating with gentiles when some Jewish Christians criticized him (Galatians 2:11–13). In response, Paul rebuked Peter for suggesting that gentiles must become Jews in order to be accepted by God (2:14–21).

No one is made right with God by keeping the law (Galatians 2:16). Even Abraham was counted as righteous because of his faith (Genesis 15:6; Galatians 3:6; James 2:21–24). It was not because of circumcision, which came later (Genesis 17:9–14). Both Jews and gentiles are brought into right relationship with God through faith, which is a response to his grace.

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 15:6; Habakkuk 2:4; Acts 10:1–11:18; Romans 1:17; Galatians 2:14–21; Galatians 3:11; Hebrews 10:38

Royal Psalms

The royal psalms all mention the king, his rule, and his relationship with God. Most scholars consider Psalms 2, 18, 20, 21, 45, 61, 72, 89, 101, 110, 132, and 144 as royal psalms.

Belief in God's rule is the foundation of the royal psalms (see Psalm 2). Each king in David's family line (King David's dynasty) acted as a messianic agent. This means they represented God's rule. As God's representative, kings descended from David had the obligation to practice justice, righteousness, faithfulness, and peace (Psalm 72:1-3).

The royal psalms express the hopes and dreams of King David's dynasty. Because of its corruption and failure, the dynasty seemed to come to an end (Psalm 89:38-45). Yet, hope continued for a future king from David's family line to serve as God's Christ. The royal psalms keep this hope alive for a king whose perfect obedience would guarantee the dynasty's continuation and the lasting benefits of his rule.

In this sense, one could also call the royal psalms messianic psalms. This is because they express hope in a Christ figure, the ideal king descended from David. Jesus stated that the writers of the psalms wrote about him (Luke 24:44). Other New Testament writers confirm that Jesus is the Messiah (God's chosen one).

Some of the most important connections to Christ are as follows:

- Psalm 2 is associated with Israel's king, the descendant of David. Yet, it describes a global victory and rule that surpasses the time of David or Solomon's rule (see Acts 13:33; Hebrews 1:5; 5:5).
- Psalm 45 is a wedding song for a king descended from David, maybe Solomon. It also mentions a lasting rule (45:6).
- Psalm 110 is the most quoted messianic psalm in the New Testament about Christ (see Matthew 22:43-45; Acts 2:34-35; Hebrews 1:13; 5:5-10; 6:20; 7:21). This psalm contains several key prophetic elements that were later understood as references to the Messiah. It describes the privileges, universal victory, and continual royal priesthood of David and his successors.

This language might seem exaggerated or misleading, except that it finds fulfillment in Jesus. The angels stand in God's presence (see Luke 1:19). But Christ the Son sits in a position of power and authority over everything at God's "right hand" (Hebrews 1:13).

Passages for Further Study

Psalms 2; 18; 20; 21; 45; 61; 72; 89; 101; 110; 132; 144; Acts 2:34-35; 13:33; Hebrews 1:5, 13; 5:5-10